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Han Qiu & Jekyung Lee

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Vertical and horizontal accountability: determinants of government transparency in China

Han Qiu^a and Jekyung Lee^b

^aSchool of Public Affairs, Zhejiang University, Hangzhou, P. R. China; ^bSchool of Public Administration, Chungnam National University, Daejeon, Republic of Korea

ABSTRACT

Influenced by a tradition of secretive public administration, China has not treated transparency as a prominent feature of its political culture. Since the adoption of *Regulations on Open Government Information* in 2007, the Chinese government has been moving towards the goal of transparent government. However, significant transparency gaps remain among subnational governments, and the mechanisms underlying these gaps are not yet well understood. Drawing on principal-agent theory, this study investigates the determinants of subnational government transparency in China using a panel dataset from 2017 to 2021. The findings reveal that transparency is predominantly shaped by political and fiscal factors, while economic factors do not reach statistical significance and social factors exert conditional influence. This evidence suggests that subnational transparency in China is primarily driven by a vertical political logic that conditions the influence of horizontal social pressures.

KEYWORDS

Government transparency;
authoritarian regimes;
principal-agent theory;
vertical accountability;
horizontal accountability

Introduction

Government transparency has become a cornerstone of contemporary public governance. By reducing information asymmetry between governments and citizens, transparency is expected to curb corruption (C. Chen & Neshkova, 2020), strengthen public trust (Yu, 2013), and enhance accountability (Hood & Heald, 2006). These expected benefits have driven a global wave of information disclosure reforms in modern history, from Sweden's Freedom of the Press Act of 1766 to more recent transparency legislation adopted by dozens of countries worldwide. In democratic settings, transparency is anchored in institutionalised mechanisms, including active local media (Bearfield & Bowman, 2017), electoral accountability (Alt et al., 2006), and citizen demand for transparency (Piotrowski & Van Ryzin, 2007).

In China, the practice of government transparency began much later than in the West, due to a long-standing culture of secrecy in public administration. In this authoritarian context, transparency operates not merely as a public resource for accountability, but as a strategic instrument for political control (Lorentzen, 2014). Despite these structural tendencies towards opacity, the central government has introduced sweeping

transparency reforms since 2007, most notably through the *Regulations on Open Government Information*. The annual Chinese Government Transparency Index, published by the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences, evaluates provincial governments, rendering their disclosure performance empirically measurable. Yet, substantial gaps persist across provinces. Some subnational governments disclose proactively and comprehensively, while others resort to minimal or symbolic compliance.

Despite a growing body of research on the determinants of government transparency (Albalade Del Sol, 2013; Baldissera et al., 2023), our understanding of subnational variation within centralised governance systems remains limited. Previous research has produced mixed and sometimes contradictory findings regarding which factors matter most, with few studies examining political, fiscal, economic, and social determinants simultaneously within a single framework. Much of this research also relies on single-country or cross-sectional designs (Adiputra et al., 2018), making it difficult to capture how these factors interact and evolve within one institutional setting over time. Moreover, the theoretical frameworks guiding this research were developed primarily in democratic contexts. Whether and how these frameworks apply to systems where information disclosure follows a fundamentally different political logic remains an open question.

To address these gaps, this study draws on principal-agent theory to identify the underlying drivers of transparency within a centralised administrative hierarchy. Specifically, we aim to answer the following research question: What factors determine the level of subnational government transparency in China, and to what extent is this transparency driven by vertical accountability pressures versus horizontal social pressures?

This study makes two main contributions. First, it develops a multi-level principal-agent framework that captures the interplay between vertical accountability and horizontal social pressures, offering a theoretical account of subnational transparency applicable to other centralised governance systems. Second, by examining political, fiscal, economic, and social determinants simultaneously using provincial panel data, this study offers a comparative assessment of their relative influence within a single institutional setting over time.

The rest of this article is organised as follows. The next section provides conceptual definitions of government transparency and reviews previous literature on its determinants. We then construct a theoretical framework that accounts for the transparency nuances of the Chinese context, followed by the development of research hypotheses. The next section details our methodology, including samples, variables, methods, and empirical models, followed by reporting the statistical results. We next discuss the main findings, and finally, the article ends with conclusions about contributions and limitations.

Literature review

With a trend emphasising transparency in government, scholars have extensively theorised about government transparency (Heald, 2006). Rather than converging on a single definition, the literature offers multiple, context-sensitive conceptualisations of government transparency (Meijer, 2013; Otenyo & Lind, 2004). Despite these variations, most scholars define government transparency as the degree of disclosure of government-related information (da Cruz et al., 2016; Grimmeliikhuijsen & Meijer, 2014). Treating